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How to Start Monetizing Your Website



March 5, 2014

We're going to go ahead and assume you already have a site. Maybe a basic WordPress site, blogger, or any of the free options available online. It just needs to be a simple site where you can upload your content and hope to potentially pull in a few bucks in the process. It's not impossible, in fact it's downright practical to assume the site you've already built could work for you and generate a little cash.

The most important step requires nearly no work at all. Just decide what your goal might be. Maybe you want to make \$200 this month, maybe more. Maybe you just want to see if it is possible to generate a single dollar through your site.

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Set Reader Expectation

Your site might already be getting a decent amount of page views each month, it might not. Either way, after you've set your personal goal, it's time to set the reader expectation on your site.

If you've had your site for a while and you've already built a following, going from a free site to one that veers more towards selling something will always rub somebody the wrong way. Your critics may get vocal and might say some hurtful things about taking the site in a monetizing direction, but **stand strong**.



Everyone loves free things, but most people understand that there's a cost involved in presenting content and will freely embrace your direction towards making a few bucks from your site.

Do your best to not get discouraged and remember that the critics are just the vocal minority. Your job is to focus on presenting the highest quality content while still serving your monetization goal.

Utilize Personal Experiences

No matter who you are, you are an expert on one very important thing. Yourself. Use your personal experiences and preferences when writing articles and selling anything.

Is the product you're selling the best you've ever used? Explain that and **make it personal**. Share your experiences, and create an aura of authority when discussing it. If you speak from the heart you'll gain readership and rack up sales.

Build Community, Gain Traction

While building a following is much easier said than done, it's not impossible. Become active in the community. Find likeminded bloggers and cross promote each other. This will drive visitors to your site, and each visitor has the potential to become a lead.

Monetization leverages traffic. Not the other way around.

Don't think that just throwing a few ads on your site will somehow create sudden windfall. Monetization leverages the traffic that you pull to your site through the content you've created. The most important aspect of monetization is continuing, and even strengthening, your content strategy.

Consider focusing your efforts around your monetization model. Dig in to the industry and culture surrounding the product you are marketing. Seek out and use products and services, then give a first-hand account of your experience with them. **Put yourself in the mind of your average visitor, what could you offer on your site that would attract them?**



Try to minimize the distance from your target visitor's interests and your own. Focus on their needs. Visitors are much more likely to convert to leads when they see that your site can fulfill their needs.

It could be through answering questions, offering up information that is otherwise hard to find, maybe even include a few web-based tools. Anything that makes your visitor's life easier will help create the urge for your visitor to return to your site.

From there, it's a matter of getting them from your site to the merchant's. How, you ask? Well, let's take a look at a few options available to start monetizing:

Affiliate Marketing Networks

Consider the Affiliate Marketing Network as a helpful jumpstart on the path to monetizing your site. There are multiple types of networks that generally pay affiliates based on a Cost Per Action (CPA).

- Cost Per Action (also referred to as Pay Per Action or PPA) generally **pays for a specific visitor action**. If the visitor performs that action after they arrived through a link from your site, you get paid! Actions that generate a payout are varied and set by each merchant. Something as simple as an impression could net you a payday. This is where a visitor comes to your site and sees the ad. Other actions are more involved and include signing up for a newsletter, registering on the merchant's site, or a final sale.
- Pay Per Lead (PPL) generally narrows the CPA requirements for payment to the affiliate only when the visitor arrives through the link provided on the affiliate's site and fills out an application to become a lead on the merchant's site.

Ad Placements

There are countless ad placement opportunities on your site. Be sure not to overload your site with banners as that may detract from reader's perception of the usefulness and legitimacy of your site.

There are two major types of ad placement revenue stipulations and it's important to understand the differences between the two.

- PPC - (Pay Per Click) This version is dependent on the Click Through Rate (CTR) of visitors actually clicking on the ad itself.
- CPM - (Cost Per Thousand) This version relates more to the overall traffic to your site. This is relating to impressions, essentially how many eyeballs see the ad on your page.

Both payment types of ad placements on your site have advantages and drawbacks. It depends on your traffic and readership. It may be worth trying both methods to see which nets you the biggest payout. There are staunch supporters of both methods so be prepared to hear people vigilantly defend what works best for them.

Email List Building

An incredibly potent tool in the quest to monetize your site is through collecting people's email addresses. If you're seeing growth in your traffic, **consider creating a regularly scheduled newsletter blast** that presents snippets of all the articles you wrote during that time. Asking for people's email is much easier if you are providing them with something that they perceive as valuable.

Once you have a list of emails, you have yet another method to present the opportunity for your visitors to follow your links to a merchant's site.

This means more chances for you to make money.

Value over Revenue

As you increase traffic and start seeing money rolling in from all your hard work, it may be tempting to start pushing harder on monetizing and spending less time increasing the value of your content. Remember: **Don't push too hard.** Trust is the largest commodity that you're selling. Once people feel like

you're pushing product just to get paid they'll run away from your site in droves.

Takeaway

Keep a realistic timetable for the growth of the traffic on your site. Also try to keep perspective with the feedback you receive from your visitors. You won't be able to please everyone. If you focus on creating great content and building the trust of your visitors, then monetizing your site is a snap!

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Hailing from Chicago and a product of the Illinois public school system, Chaz Wilke is a professional writer who has written for newspaper, TV, radio, video games, blogs, and film. In his spare time, Chaz enjoys hiking and discovering the hidden gems and oddities of Los Angeles. He also juggles.

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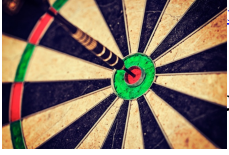
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